Payments Service: Incident Runbook Excerpts

Platform Engineering

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1 Overview

This document collects the boxed callouts used in the payments service runbook. Every box follows the house style set with `\tcbset`: a white body, a dark blue frame, and a bold title. Admonitions that apply to the whole page use the custom `keypoint` environment, which renders with an amber frame so it stands out from ordinary notes.

Scope

These excerpts cover the deploy freeze calendar, the rollback checklist, and the on-call escalation path. They do not cover database failover, which has its own runbook.

Key point

During the holiday freeze—the last two weeks of December—no production deploys are allowed without written approval from two service owners.

2 Escalation

The escalation path below uses the `skins` library's enhanced skin with a soft drop shadow, which the team reserves for boxes that must catch the eye during an incident.

Escalation path

Page the primary on-call first. If there is no acknowledgement within ten minutes, page the secondary. If the incident is customer-facing and unresolved after thirty minutes, declare a major incident and summon the incident commander.

3 Rollback Checklist

The rollback checklist is the longest box in the runbook: it usually runs past the page break, so it is declared breakable and allowed to split across pages.

Rollback checklist (v14)

Confirm that the deploy pipeline is paused before touching anything; a second deploy landing mid-rollback has caused two of the last five rollback incidents. Announce the rollback in the incidents channel with the release number, the reason, and the expected duration, so that support can set customer expectations early.

Drain traffic from the new revision one availability zone at a time, waiting for the health checks to go green on the old revision before moving to the next zone. The load balancer target groups are named `payments-blue` and `payments-green`; the runbook assumes blue is live, but verify against the deploy ticket rather than trusting the colour, because the colours swap on every release.

Watch the error budget dashboard while each zone drains. A brief spike in 5xx responses is normal as connections migrate, but if the burn rate stays above the fast-burn threshold for more than five minutes, stop the drain and escalate: the old revision may itself be unhealthy, and completing the rollback would only move the incident.

Once all zones serve the old revision, run the smoke suite from the operations host, not from a laptop: the suite needs the production VPN routes, and the VPN client on laptops drops idle connections after fifteen minutes. The suite takes about six minutes; all forty-two checks must pass before the rollback is declared complete.

File the rollback report within one business day. The report needs the timeline, the graphs, and a link to the deploy diff, plus a judgement on whether the release can be re-attempted or must be reverted in source control. Attach the report to the original deploy ticket so the history stays in one place.

Finally, schedule the retrospective within a week while memories are fresh. The template is in the shared drive under *Engineering / Incident templates*. Invite the deploy author, the reviewer, and the on-call who performed the rollback; incidents without a retrospective within two weeks are flagged in the engineering review.

Key point

A rollback is complete only when the smoke suite passes on the old revision and the rollback report is filed. Draining traffic is necessary but not sufficient.